include the people and their customs, gleaning most of his information from local Brahmins.[5] ‘The divisions of the Brahmans here are different from those found in Bengal,’ Buchanan observed, noting also the fierce rivalry existing between the Shaiva Brahmins, who were followers of Shankara, and the Iyengar Brahmins, who were Vaishnavas and in many instances followed secular professions as well as filling nearly all the government posts: ‘They are called *Sri Vaishnavum* and *A’ayngar*, and may be readily known by the three vertical marks, connected by a common mark on the forehead, connected by a common line above the nose, and formed of white clay. They abhor *Isvara* [Shiva], calling him the chief of the *Rakshasa*, or devils, and worship only Vishnu, and the gods of his family.’ The remaining Brahmins were more easy-going, ‘thinking Vishnu to be the father of Brahma, and Brahma the father of Siva’.

However, as Buchanan entered the Malabar country by way of the Palakkad Gap he observed a marked change in society. He was particularly struck by the prosperity of the local Brahmins, who were very comfortably settled in their own communities, called *agraharam*s, where their houses stood in two rows either side of a road running north and south, with a temple to the local deity at the centre and temples to Shiva and Vishnu at either end. ‘They are the neatest and cleanest villages I have seen in India,’ Buchanan noted. ‘The beauty, cleanness and elegant dress of the girls of the Brahmans add much to the look of these places.’

The Nairs, by contrast, preferred to live in individual households in the countryside but were as well-turned-out as the Brahmins, even though both communities made a point of keeping each other at arm’s length – and the rest of the population at an ever greater distance. ‘The whole of these Nairs formed the militia of Malayala, directed by the Namburis, and governed by the Rajas,’ observed Buchanan.